

Josh Sharma Match Prep Report

Opponent: Josh Sharma, England, FIDE 477702, ECF 307395G, Maidenhead | Prepared for Lachlan Tyrrell | Source: local En Croissant prep folder

Bottom line: Josh is a practical dynamic player with repeatable opening habits. With White, his main historical weapon is the Jobava/London family with d4, Nc3 and Bf4, often followed by e3 and h4/g4. Recently he has also used 1.e4. With Black he is strongest and most comfortable in 1.e4 e5 open games, especially Italian/Two Knights and Ruy Lopez structures. Against Nf3/c4/d4 he often goes ...Nf6, ...g6 and ...Bg7, but his pure KID-core results in this sample are a pressure point.

Data point	Value	Prep meaning
Raw Josh PGN files	85	The folder has 85 game files after excluding the repertoire file.
Unique games for stats	66	Deduped by result and movetext to avoid counting Chess-Results, Mega and Lichess copies twice.
Date span	2021-10-02 to 2025-08-10	Useful recent form exists, but some 2026 ECF games have no public PGN.
Overall score	36/66, 54.5%	Solid practical results, not an opponent who is simply rolling the field.
Since 2024	20/34, 58.8%	Recent trend is stronger than the full historical sample.
2025 British Major	5/9, 55.6%	The local folder has duplicate round files; deduped event score is 5/9.
Chess.com account	None credible	Do not import speculative online games into prep.

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1. Executive Summary

- Treat him as a dynamic practical player, not a quiet positional technician. He likes positions with clear plans and tactical pressure, especially where he knows the recurring motifs.
- His White repertoire is targetable: 19 of 32 unique White games are Jobava/London style with 1.d4, Nc3 and Bf4. The exact recurring setups include e3+h4, e3+g4, Nb5, and e4/Qd2 ideas.
- His latest complete public event shows a real 1.e4 phase: Italian, French Advance, Caro-Kann Fantasy and open-centre systems. Do not assume he will only play d4.
- As Black against 1.e4 he is most reliable: Two Knights/Italian with ...Nf6 scored 5.5/8, Ruy Lopez ...a6/...d6 scored 3/5, and central ...exd4 setups scored well in a tiny sample.
- As Black against non-1.e4 he is a fianchetto player. He does play KID structures, but the pure KID-core subset scored only 1.5/6 in this sample; that is the clearest strategic target if you get White.

2. Style, Strengths And Weaknesses

Style Profile

Josh's style is practical and dynamic. He repeatedly chooses systems that create imbalance while still giving him a familiar structure: Jobava/London with White, 1...e5 open games with Black, and fianchetto systems against queen-pawn or flank openings. The recurring theme is controlled imbalance, not random chaos. He is happy to invite tactical contact if he knows the pattern.

He also plays long games. The sample contains many games reaching 50+ moves, so do not expect one clean opening surprise to end the game. If you win the opening, the job is still to convert steadily.

Strength	Evidence	How to respond
Opening consistency	Jobava/London is 19/32 White games; 1...e5 is his main answer to 1.e4.	Prepare concrete move orders, not just general ideas.
Open-game tactics	Two Knights/Italian as Black scored 5.5/8.	Avoid giving him a familiar forcing line unless you have checked it.
Counterplay instinct	He accepts structural concessions in Ruy/KID/fianchetto lines if piece activity follows.	Make him prove compensation; trade into better structures when available.
Endurance	Several long games and practical saves/draws.	Stay patient. Do not relax after winning the first phase.

Weakness	Evidence	How to exploit
Predictable White systems	The d4/Nc3/Bf4 family dominates older White games.	Have one anti-Jobava plan ready to move 10, especially against h4/g4.
KID-core results	As Black in ...Nf6/...g6/...Bg7 plus ...d6/e5 setups: 1.5/6.	With White, steer toward Catalan/Reti/fianchetto pressure and make him solve structure.
Risky open-game defence	He repeats sharp Two Knights structures; results are good but volatile.	If you enter them, know the forcing lines. Otherwise sidestep with positional systems.
Recent 1.e4 still mixed	French Advance scored 1/3; his 1.e4 repertoire is less established than Jobava.	If you are Black and he plays e4, aim for your most familiar structure and make him think independently.

3. His White Repertoire

Prep priority if you have Black: Be ready for both 1.d4 and 1.e4. The historical main weapon is Jobava/London, but the latest full event sample is mostly 1.e4. Your anti-London files are high-value, but also review your normal answer to 1.e4 for Italian, French Advance, Caro Fantasy and Pirc/Modern-style open centres.

White setup	Games	Score	Specific move orders seen
Jobava/London: 1.d4 + Nc3/Bf4	19	10.5/19	Most repeated: 1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.Bf4, then e3 plus h4/g4/Nf3/Nb5/e4 depending on Black setup.
Open Sicilian / Scotch-style centre	4	2/4	1.e4 followed by Nf3 and d4; against ...Nc6/...d6/...Nf6/...g6 he used Nc3 and Be2.
French Advance	3	1/3	1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.e5 c5 4.c3, then Nf3 and Be2/Bd3.
Italian/Open Game as White	2	1/2	1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4, then c3 and d4 when allowed.
Caro-Kann Fantasy	1	1/2	1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.f3 dxe4 4.fxe4 e5.
Queen-pawn mainline c4	2	2/2	Occasional d4/c4/Nf3 systems; not the main trend but he can play normal queen-pawn chess.

Jobava/London detail

- Most common exact family: d4, Nc3, Bf4, e3, then h4. This occurred six times in the deduped sample and is the clearest autopilot pattern.
- He also uses e3 plus g4, usually to seize kingside space before Black has hit the centre hard enough.
- When Black allows it, he can play e4 or Qd2, shifting from a London shell into a direct central/kingside game.
- Against ...c5 structures, he is willing to take on c5 or advance/overextend with d5; your prep should include the ...Qa5+ and ...Qxc5 idea from your file.

Recent 1.e4 detail

- Against 1...e5 he used Italian-style development: Bc4, c3, d4. He is trying to build a classical centre and open lines rather than play a slow Italian manoeuvring game.
- Against the French he used the Advance: e5, c3, Nf3, Be2/Bd3. His score there is modest, so a prepared French player should be happy.
- Against the Caro-Kann he tried Fantasy with f3. This is sharp and practical; meet it with a concrete line, not general development.
- Against a Pirc/Modern/Nimzowitsch type move order he has used Nf3, d4, Nc3 and Be2, not an all-out Austrian Attack in the available sample.

4. His Black Repertoire

Prep priority if you have White: Avoid giving him the exact 1.e4 e5 open-game structures where his results are best unless you have a forcing line ready. Your Catalan/Reti files fit the target: make him choose between KID-core, fianchetto ...d5/...c5, or classical queen-pawn structures, then press the structural weaknesses.

Black setup	Games	Score	Specific move orders seen
1.e4 e5: Two Knights / Italian ...Nf6	8	5.5/8	1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Nf6, often meeting d4/e5 with ...exd4, ...d5, ...Nd7.
1.e4 e5: Ruy Lopez	5	3/5	1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bb5 a6 4.Ba4 Nf6 5.O-O d6, then ...Bd7 and sometimes ...g6/...Bg7.
1.e4 e5: Scotch/central	2	1.5/2	1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4, including ...Bb4+ against Nxd4/c3.
KID core	6	1.5/6	Against d4/c4/Nf3: ...Nf6, ...g6, ...Bg7, ...d6 and often ...e5. This is a target.
Fianchetto with ...d5/...c5	4	2.5/4	Recent: ...Nf6, ...g6, ...d5, ...Bg7, ...c5 against d4/Nf3/f4 setups.
Classical queen-pawn	3	2/3	...d5, ...Nf6, ...e6 structures when he does not fianchetto.

Against 1.e4

- His main answer is 1...e5. In the deduped open-game sample, the pattern is very clear: ...Nc6 almost always follows.
- The Two Knights/Italian branch is his best-scoring setup. In the 2025 British Major he played the same Bc4/Nf6/d4/e5 structure against Arnott and Nicholas, winning one and losing one. That line is playable but tactically sharp for both sides.
- The Ruy Lopez branch is not a mainline closed Spanish. He often chooses ...d6 and sometimes ...g6/...Bg7, creating a Steinitz/Pirc-flavoured Spanish. White can often target the d6/e5 structure and dark squares.
- He has only one deduped Sicilian as Black, so do not expect Sicilian preparation to be central.

Against 1.d4 / 1.Nf3 / 1.c4 / 1.f4

- Yes, he plays the King's Indian Defence. The clearest KID-core move order is 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 Bg7 4.e4 d6, followed by ...O-O and ...e5.
- He also reaches KID-like structures from Nf3/c4/g3 move orders: ...Nf6, ...g6, ...Bg7, ...O-O, ...d6, then ...e5 or ...c5.
- Recently he has also used a fianchetto-with-...d5 setup: Bhatia-Sharma 2025 began 1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3 g6 3.Nbd2 d5 4.e3 Bg7 5.Bd3 O-O 6.O-O c5.
- The pure KID-core subset is his worst-scoring Black bucket. That does not mean the KID is bad, but it does mean you should welcome those structures if you know your plans.

5. Recent Form And Most Recent Openings

The freshest complete public event in the local folder is the 2025 British Chess Championships Major Open. The raw folder has duplicate source copies for some rounds; deduped, this is nine games and a 5/9 score. The openings show a clear recent 1.e4 experiment with White and his usual 1...e5 or fianchetto systems with Black.

Date	Side	Result	Opponent	Opening sketch
2025-08-02	Black	Win	Nus	Ruy Lopez: e4 e5 Nf3 Nc6 Bb5 a6 Ba4 Nf6 O-O d6; later ...g6.
2025-08-03	White	Draw	Wall	1.e4 Nc6 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nf6 4.Nc3 g6 5.Be2.
2025-08-04	Black	Loss	Bhatia	d4/Nf3 vs ...Nf6/...g6/...d5/...Bg7/...c5.
2025-08-05	White	Win	Islam	Italian: e4 e5 Nf3 Nc6 Bc4 Bc5 c3 Nf6 d4.
2025-08-06	Black	Win	Arnott	Two Knights/Italian: Bc4 Nf6 d4 exd4 e5 d5.
2025-08-07	White	Draw	Potter	French Advance: e4 e6 d4 d5 e5 c5 c3 Nc6.
2025-08-08	Black	Loss	Nicholas	Same Two Knights/Italian family; tactical and long.
2025-08-09	White	Draw	Brown	Caro-Kann Fantasy: e4 c6 d4 d5 f3.
2025-08-10	Black	Draw	Bennett	Bird/Stonewall-ish: f4 Nf6 Nf3 g6 d3 d5 e3 Bg7 c5.

6. Your Game Plan

If You Are Black

Primary target: Prepare for 1.d4 with Nc3/Bf4. If he plays this, your job is to challenge the centre before h4/g4 becomes a free attack. Your current anti-London files are directly relevant.

- 1 Against 1.d4 Nf6 2.Bf4, use your prepared early ...c5 or KID-style setup. The cleanest practical idea from your files is ...c5, ...Nd5, ...Qb6 and pressure on d4/b2, or ...g6/...Bg7 followed by ...c5 before he attacks for free.

- Against 1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.Bf4, do not drift into a passive London. Prepare the immediate central challenge: ...c5, ...e6, ...Qb6/...Qa5+ motifs, and be ready for e3, h4, g4, Nb5 and e4.
- If he plays early h4 or g4, answer in the centre. The practical aim is to make those pawns targets, not to spend tempi reacting to them on the wing.
- If he plays 1.e4, expect either an Italian if you answer 1...e5, a French Advance if you play the French, a Fantasy if you play the Caro, or a restrained Be2 setup against Pirc/Modern-style development. Pick your most familiar line and know the first tactical contact.

Likely White setup	Your target	Do not allow
d4/Nc3/Bf4/e3/h4	Hit d4 with ...c5 and use ...Qb6 or ...Qa5+ motifs.	A free h4-h5/g4 attack while your centre stays passive.
d4/Nc3/Bf4/e3/g4	Open the centre or trade his d-pawn before the kingside is fixed.	Slow developing moves that let him castle long or attack first.
1.e4 Italian	Challenge d4 cleanly; know whether you play ...exd4 and ...d5 or a quieter setup.	Entering a forcing Bc4/Nf6 line without checking tactics.
French Advance	Pressure d4/c3 with ...c5, ...Nc6, ...Qb6.	Letting him build e5/c3/Nf3/Bd3 with no counterplay.

If You Are White

Primary target: Use Catalan/Reti structures to make him defend a positional game. His best Black bucket is 1.e4 e5 tactics; his weakest is KID-core/fianchetto structures when White keeps pressure without over-forcing.

- Start with 1.Nf3 or 1.d4/2.c4 if that fits your comfort. Your repertoire files already support Nf3/c4/g3 and Catalan structures.
- If he goes ...Nf6, ...g6, ...Bg7, build c4, d4, g3, Bg2, O-O, Nc3 or Nbd2 depending on move order, then choose between d5, cxd5, or dxe5 when it improves the structure.
- If he chooses KID-core with ...d6 and ...e5, welcome it. The sample score is poor for him. Your aim is a stable centre, pressure on d6/e5, and trades that leave his dark-square weaknesses visible.
- If he plays fianchetto with ...d5/...c5, transpose toward Catalan/Reti pressure. Your Catalan accepted file is useful when he takes on c4 or opens the c-file.
- Avoid casual 1.e4 e5 mainlines unless you have a line ready. That is his most comfortable Black territory.

Josh setup as Black	Your recommended setup	Plan
...Nf6/...g6/...Bg7/...d6/e5	Nf3, c4, g3, Bg2, d4	Fianchetto pressure; decide between d5, dxe5 and cxd5 based on structure.
...Nf6/...g6/...d5/...c5	Catalan/Reti	Keep tension, pressure c/d files, punish premature queenside expansion.
...d5/...Nf6/...e6	Catalan or QGD with g3	Make his light-square bishop problem concrete; use c4 pressure.
1.e4 e5 open game	Avoid unless prepared	He is comfortable here; do not give him his best practical arena for free.

7. Before-The-Round Checklist

- Review Black rep / Black against the london system.pgn: especially the KID-style setup with ...g6, ...Bg7, ...d6 and the timely ...c5 break.
- Review Black rep / c5! against the london.pgn: especially 1.d4 Nf6 2.Bf4 c5 3.e3 Nd5 4.Bg3 Qb6 and the ...cxd4 / ...Qb6 pressure patterns.

- Add or mentally rehearse the transposition 1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.Bf4, because Josh often reaches the Jobava move order with Nc3 before Bf4.
- Review White rep / Catalan accepted as white.pgn: especially dxc5 against ...c5 and the queen/knight routes to recover c4 cleanly.
- Review White rep / Reti, Nf3, d5, c4.pgn: especially Nf3/c4/g3 against ...Nf6/...g6 and Queen's Indian-style ...b6 setups.
- Prepare one forcing calculation line against his Two Knights/Italian if you might play 1.e4, or decide now to avoid 1.e4 entirely.

If this appears	Your cue	Practical action
Josh: d4, Nc3, Bf4	This is his main historical comfort zone.	Play your anti-Jobava plan quickly; no passive London setup.
Josh: e4	Recent British Major trend.	Use your most familiar defence and expect a central d4 push.
Josh as Black: ...Nf6/...g6	He may choose KID or ...d5 fianchetto.	Go Catalan/Reti; maintain tension and target d6/e5 or c-file weaknesses.
Josh as Black: e4 e5	His best-scoring Black family.	Avoid unless prepared; if entered, calculate forcing d4/e5 lines.

8. Appendix: Representative Setups

These are not full repertoire lines; they are scouting patterns to recognize quickly over the board.

Setup	Representative line	Read
Jobava/London attack	1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.Bf4 e6 4.e3, then h4 or g4	He wants a known attacking shell. Break with ...c5 and make the centre matter.
Jobava vs ...g6	1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.Bf4 g6 4.e3 Bg7 5.h4/c5	He may attack before development is complete. Use ...c5 and queen pressure.
Italian as White	1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Bc5 4.c3 Nf6 5.d4	He plays for central contact, not a quiet manoeuvring Italian.
French Advance	1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.e5 c5 4.c3	His results are modest; standard pressure on d4/c3 is welcome.
Two Knights as Black	1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Nf6 4.d4 exd4 5.e5 d5	Sharp, theoretical, and one of his better-scoring zones.
Ruy Lopez as Black	1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bb5 a6 4.Ba4 Nf6 5.O-O d6	He often chooses a flexible but slightly passive ...d6 shell.
KID core as Black	1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 Bg7 4.e4 d6 5.Nf3 O-O 6.Be2 e5	A real part of his repertoire, but a statistical target in this sample.
Fianchetto ...d5	1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3 g6 3.Nbd2 d5 4.e3 Bg7 5.Bd3 O-O 6.O-O c5	Recent practical choice; treat like Catalan/Reti pressure, not a pure KID.

9. Sources And Limits

Limit note: no fresh engine pass was run for this report. Tactical and positional conclusions are scouting inferences from openings, results, structures and representative games.

- Local source folder: C:\Users\loxy\Documents\EnCroissant\Oxford FIDE Congress U2300 player games\Sharma, Josh [cc none credible]
- Raw source files: 85 Josh PGN files. A separate repertoire file in the folder was excluded from statistics.
- Statistical source: 66 unique games after deduping by result and movetext to avoid duplicate Mega, Chess-Results and Lichess copies.

Update: Fianchetto Shells - KID or ...d5?

Short answer: he leans slightly KID-ish in the relevant local sample, but it is close enough that you should prepare both branches. The better read is move-order dependent: full-centre systems invite ...d6; slower Nf3/e3/Bd3 or Bird-style setups often get ...d5 + ...c5.

Scope checked	Count	Prep meaning
Deduped Josh Black games	32	Overall Black sample after dropping obvious duplicate source copies.
Relevant d4/flank fianchetto shell	9	Games where Josh used ...Nf6, ...g6 and ...Bg7 outside the 1.e4 e5 Spanish family.
...d6 first / KID-ish	5	Slight majority; especially when White builds d4+c4 with Nc3/e4 or a Catalan/Reti centre.
...d5 first / Gruenfeld-ish	4	Very live practical choice; most recent non-1.e4 fianchetto examples in 2025 went this way.
Spanish/Ruy fianchetto excluded	3	Those are 1.e4 e5 games where ...g6 is a later defensive setup, not a queen-pawn repertoire signal.

How To Read His Choice

If you show the full centre with d4+c4 and then Nc3/e4, expect more KID: ...d6, ...O-O, ...e5, sometimes ...Nbd7 or ...a5/Na6.
Example: 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 Bg7 4.e4 d6 5.Nf3 O-O 6.Be2 e5.

If you keep it slow with Nf3/e3/Bd3/Nbd2, or if you start Bird-style with f4, his recent habit is more ...d5, ...c5, ...Nc6 and often ...Bg4/Qc7 pressure. Example: 1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3 g6 3.Nbd2 d5 4.e3 Bg7 5.Bd3 O-O 6.O-O c5.

Do not call him a pure Gruenfeld player. The sample does not show a clear mainline Gruenfeld commitment after 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5. His ...d5 is more of a practical fianchetto/neo-Gruenfeld answer to restrained setups.

Recent warning: Bhatia-Sharma 2025 and Bennett-Sharma 2025 both reached ...d5 + ...c5 structures, so this branch deserves real board prep even though ...d6 slightly leads the historical count.

Your Practical Answer With White

Josh chooses	Your cue	Plan
...d6 / KID-ish	He wants ...e5 or ...c5 counterplay after castling.	Stay in Catalan/Reti comfort: c4, g3, Bg2, d4. Keep central tension; if he commits ...e5, choose in advance whether you are taking on e5 for a small structural pull or maintaining tension with Nc3/Re1.
...d5 + ...c5	He is trying to make your slow setup concrete before you finish development.	Treat it like a Catalan/Gruenfeld hybrid. Watch ...Bg4 and ...Ne4 hits; be ready for dxc5 or cxd5, Qa4+/Ne5 resources, and pressure on the c-file.
Early ...Bg4	This appears in several fianchetto structures.	Do not allow a free pin plus ...cxd4. Decide whether h3, Be3, or Nbd2 fits your chosen move order.
Delayed ...d6 after ...c5	Benoni/KID hybrid possibility.	Avoid drifting into passivity. If he gives you d5 space, play for queenside restraint and make him prove kingside counterplay.

One-Line Match Prep Verdict

Prepare your main line for **...d6 KID structures**, but in the actual game use his early move order as the tell: if he delays ...d6 and plays ...d5 quickly against your restrained setup, switch mindset immediately to Catalan/Gruenfeld pressure and do not let ...Bg4, ...Ne4 or ...cxd4 arrive with tempo.

Added after the KID vs ...d5 check: counts are from local parsed PGNs only, deduped by players/result/opening move sequence. Confidence high for the count split; medium for style inference without a fresh engine pass.